

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Housekeeping and Commercial Cleaning English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Housekeeping attendants, commercial cleaners, custodial staff, and cleaning team members.

All room numbers, buildings, times, counts, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice, not cleaning certification, chemical-use instruction, medical advice, or access authorization. Follow employer training and site procedures for products, equipment, privacy, waste, and hazards. Do not infer permission to enter, mix products, handle unknown waste, or repair equipment. This course addresses frontline cleaning exchanges rather than hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Confirming the assignment and its limits

Clarify the requested surfaces and the boundary of the current assignment.

02 Respecting access and occupied spaces

Agree a practical service choice with an occupant.

03 Clarifying product and task information

Describe missing product information and request qualified help.

04 Reporting faults and unsafe access

Report location, observation, and unresolved status without a technical diagnosis.

05 Handling found items and privacy questions

Give observable details and obtain a receiving acknowledgment.

06 Counting linen and replenishing supplies

State target, actual count, and difference for each item.

07 Responding to a quality concern

Clarify a quality concern and agree a check of the specific area.

08 Giving a clear end-of-shift handover

Give each area a precise status and a named follow-up.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Confirming the assignment and its limits

Clarify the requested surfaces and the boundary of the current assignment.

CASE

A commercial assignment says 'conference room: tables and floor.' The client asks for 'everything' before a 3:00 meeting. The worker is assigned table surfaces and the floor, not high windows or personal equipment. The supervisor can clarify extra work; the meeting time doesn't expand permission.

Teach this move

A broad request may contain extra work or items the cleaner should not move. Name the included work and ask about the rest.

Vocabulary to check: assignment sheet, service scope, touchpoint, spot cleaning.

Model response

The assignment covers the conference-room table surfaces and floor. When you say everything, are you also asking about the high windows and personal equipment? Those aren't included in my current task list. I can complete the listed work and ask my supervisor to review the additional request before anyone promises it for three o'clock.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised statement gives a precise commitment.

Second-round challenge

The client adds laptops to 'tables.' Clarify that cleaning around personal equipment differs from handling it.

Language-check answers

1. A - outside Correct. The current assignment covers tables and floor, not high windows.
2. B - spot cleaning Correct. Spot cleaning targets the particular marked area.

05 • Conversations

1. Everything has a boundary - The conference-room assignment in the case.
2. A spot or the whole carpet? - A cleaner clarifies a client's request about a marked carpet.
3. Touchpoints in the corridor - A team member clarifies the location of a daily task.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Furniture is not part of the floor request

A client asks for a meeting-room floor cleaned but heavy display units block one corner. The cleaner isn't assigned to move them. The supervisor can review access.

Role A: Cleaner: explain the inaccessible corner.

Role B: Client: arrange staff assistance or accept a recorded limitation.

Possible opening: I can reach the open floor, but that corner is blocked by the display units.

Success checks

- Name the blocked area.
- Avoid assuming permission or ability to move heavy units.
- Agree who resolves access and how completion is described.

Add a complication: The client assumes 'floor cleaning' includes moving all furniture.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Respecting access and occupied spaces

Agree a practical service choice with an occupant.

CASE

A guest in room 312 declines cleaning at 10:00 because of a call until 11:00. The attendant's return window is 11:15-11:30. The guest can choose a visit in that window or fresh towels at the door now. No room entry is authorized by this conversation alone.

Teach this move

A return appointment and permission to enter are separate. State the available window instead of promising an exact minute you can't control.

Vocabulary to check: do-not-disturb notice, occupied room, access window, service refusal.

Model response

I understand you're on a call until eleven. I can offer a return between eleven fifteen and eleven thirty, or bring fresh towels to the door now if that is all you need. Which would you prefer? I'll record your choice, and we'll still follow the room-access arrangements when I return.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The guest gets a choice rather than an announced entry.

Second-round challenge

The guest says 'after my call' without confirming a time. Offer the actual window again.

Language-check answers

1. A - return window Correct. A window gives a range of times.
2. B - instead of Correct. The guest chooses towels as the replacement service.

05 • Conversations

1. A service choice at the door - Room 312 at 10:00, following the case.
2. A meeting runs beyond the access window - A cleaner negotiates access with an office occupant.

3. A sign and a verbal message conflict - An attendant asks the supervisor about contradictory room-access information.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A locked meeting room

A cleaner has an assignment for room B at 7:00, but the door is locked and the cleaner has no approved access method. The office contact can arrange access at 7:30.

Role A: Cleaner: explain the obstacle and available work elsewhere.

Role B: Office contact: offer 7:30 access; do not ask the cleaner to improvise entry.

Possible opening: The room is locked, so that part of the assignment hasn't started.

Success checks

- Distinguish vacancy from access.
- Agree the 7:30 check.
- Keep completion status accurate.

Add a complication: The contact says the room is empty, but that doesn't supply access.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying product and task information

Describe missing product information and request qualified help.

CASE

A bottle on the cart has an unreadable label. A colleague identifies it by color, but two products use similar bottles. The cleaner has not used it. The supervisor can identify it and provide the relevant product information or a clearly identified replacement. No chemical steps are taught.

Teach this move

The same color or bottle shape can belong to different products. Knowing a nickname isn't the same as identifying the actual container.

Vocabulary to check: product label, Safety Data Sheet, cleaning, disinfection.

Model response

I can't identify this bottle from its unreadable label, and its color doesn't resolve which product it contains. I haven't used it. Could you help confirm the product and its current information, or provide a clearly identified replacement? I need that resolved before I continue the assigned task with this bottle.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised explanation names the unresolved fact.

Second-round challenge

The colleague offers a nickname. Request the exact product information from the supervisor.

Language-check answers

1. C - unverified Correct. Appearance hasn't established the actual product identity.
2. C - the SDS matching Product B Correct. The Safety Data Sheet must identify the actual product being checked.

05 • Conversations

1. The blue bottle isn't identified - The unreadable-label case at a cleaning cart.
2. Cleaning isn't a disinfection claim - A cleaner clarifies a client's description of completed work.
3. A different label on a familiar product - A cleaner notices a revised product name before starting work.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A borrowed sheet names another product

A colleague offers a Safety Data Sheet whose product name differs from the container's label. The cleaner has not used the product; the supervisor can locate matching information.

Role A: Cleaner: point out the exact mismatch.

Role B: Colleague: accept that a document for a similar product isn't the same record.

Possible opening: The product name on this sheet doesn't match the bottle.

Success checks

- Compare exact product names.
- Avoid transferring instructions between products.
- Request matching current information.

Add a complication: The colleague says both products perform the same kind of cleaning.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reporting faults and unsafe access

Report location, observation, and unresolved status without a technical diagnosis.

CASE

Water is visible on the floor outside washroom B, beside the east stair door. The cleaner doesn't know the source and has reported it under site arrangements. The supervisor needs an exact location and confirmation that the area has not been declared ready. No plumbing diagnosis or cleanup method is requested.

Teach this move

'Water near a door' is less useful than a specific washroom and landmark. Request the appropriate responder rather than offering repair steps.

Vocabulary to check: hazard report, maintenance request, out-of-service notice, affected area.

Model response

There is water on the floor outside washroom B, beside the east stair door. I don't know its source, and I haven't marked that area ready. Please arrange the appropriate site response and tell me who is taking the follow-up. I'll report the location and current restriction clearly to the next team.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The report gives a checkable location without claiming a cause.

Second-round challenge

A passerby says the floor was cleaned earlier. Explain why the present water still needs reporting.

Language-check answers

1. C - unknown Correct. The cleaner observed water without establishing its cause.
2. B - outside Correct. Outside locates the water beyond the washroom entrance.

05 • Conversations

1. Water beside the east stair door - The washroom B report in the case.
2. The noise is not a diagnosis - A cleaner reports a vacuum problem without repair instructions.

3. A recurring mark may need maintenance - A cleaner reports a recurring ceiling stain without identifying its cause.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A notice belongs to another machine

Two floor machines stand together. One has an out-of-service notice identifying unit F3. The second is F8. The cleaner hasn't checked F8's readiness.

Role A: Cleaner: report F3's notice without assuming F8 is ready.

Role B: Lead: confirm the exact equipment identifiers and arrange the separate readiness check.

Possible opening: The notice names F3; I haven't confirmed F8's status.

Success checks

- Identify F3 correctly.
- Keep F8's readiness separate.
- Request confirmation instead of inferring it from appearance.

Add a complication: A colleague treats absence of a notice as proof of readiness.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handling found items and privacy questions

Give observable details and obtain a receiving acknowledgment.

CASE

An attendant finds a closed black glasses case beneath the chair in room 214 after checkout. The owner is unknown. The attendant should report visible details without opening it and transfer it to the designated lost-property receiver, who can confirm receipt. Don't identify an owner from a guess.

Teach this move

Finding an item in a room doesn't prove who owns it. Describe the exterior and location without inspecting private contents or publicly disclosing guest information.

Vocabulary to check: lost property, item description, found location, custody record.

Model response

I found a closed black glasses case beneath the chair in room two-fourteen. I haven't opened it, and I don't know whose it is. Could you receive it through the lost-property arrangement and confirm the transfer? Please keep the found location separate from its storage location so any later inquiry uses the correct details.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The description separates observation from an ownership guess.

Second-round challenge

A colleague asks you to name the previous guest in a public area. Keep the inquiry with the designated receiver.

Language-check answers

1. A - Under Correct. 'Under' matches the stated location beneath the chair.
2. B - I've received the closed black case Correct. This names the item and confirms completed receipt.

05 • Conversations

1. A case under the chair - The room 214 lost-property handover.
2. Papers beside a bin aren't necessarily waste - A commercial cleaner asks about loose documents.
3. A visitor asks for someone else's property - A cleaner redirects an ownership claim to the designated team.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Found location versus storage location

A cleaner found a scarf on the third-floor lounge sofa. It is now held by the designated office on the ground floor. A colleague asks where it was found.

Role A: Cleaner: distinguish discovery and current custody.

Role B: Colleague: repeat both locations accurately.

Possible opening: It was found upstairs, but the ground-floor office now holds it.

Success checks

- Name the lounge sofa as the found location.
- Name the office as current custody.
- Correct the record without adding ownership assumptions.

Add a complication: The colleague starts recording the ground-floor office as the found location.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Counting linen and replenishing supplies

State target, actual count, and difference for each item.

CASE

The third-floor cart target is twelve bath towels and eight hand towels. The attendant counts nine bath towels and eight hand towels. A laundry delivery is expected but not confirmed. Report the three-bath-towel shortfall without calling all linen unavailable.

Teach this move

Separate item types and distinguish an expected delivery from available stock. A shortfall in one item doesn't mean every linen item is unavailable.

Vocabulary to check: linen, replenishment, par stock, discrepancy.

Model response

The cart has nine bath towels and eight hand towels. Against today's target of twelve and eight, we're short three bath towels; the hand-towel count is complete. A laundry delivery is expected, but its arrival isn't confirmed. Could you check whether three bath towels can be allocated from available stock?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The next person knows exactly what needs replenishment.

Second-round challenge

Another floor requests two towels from this cart. Explain the effect on its count before any reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - three bath towels Correct. Twelve minus nine leaves three bath towels.
2. A - expected this afternoon, but unconfirmed Correct. This preserves the expected timing without claiming verification.

05 • Conversations

1. Only the bath towels are short - The third-floor cart count from the case.
2. A carton count hides the refill type - A cleaner checks supplies delivered to an office washroom.

3. An allocation isn't extra stock - A room attendant checks whether linen in another cart is available.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A changed room allocation changes the target

An attendant's cart has ten bath towels for a ten-towel assignment. The supervisor adds two rooms requiring four more bath towels under the fictional plan. No extra towels have arrived.

Role A: Attendant: state the revised target and shortfall.

Role B: Supervisor: confirm fourteen total and arrange four additional towels.

Possible opening: Does the added assignment raise my bath-towel target from ten to fourteen?

Success checks

- Confirm fourteen as the new target.
- Report four additional towels needed.
- Keep assignment change separate from delivered stock.

Add a complication: A colleague counts the original ten as though the new rooms were already covered.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Responding to a quality concern

Clarify a quality concern and agree a check of the specific area.

CASE

A client reports streaks on the interior glass panel beside office 8, cleaned earlier that day. The cleaner can acknowledge the reported result and ask the lead to arrange a check and appropriate rework. The cause is unknown; the client is available to point out the panel.

Teach this move

'It was cleaned' doesn't mean every result meets the task requirement. Listen for the exact surface and defect instead of defending how long the task took.

Vocabulary to check: inspection, rework, residue, streak.

Model response

Thank you for showing me the streaks on the interior panel beside office eight. That is the panel on today's completed task list. I'm sorry the result needs attention. I'll ask our lead to check it and arrange the appropriate rework. I don't know the cause yet, so I'll report the visible marks rather than guess.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision acknowledges both earlier work and the present concern.

Second-round challenge

The client says all windows must be poor. Keep the confirmed concern limited to the identified panel.

Language-check answers

1. D - streaks Correct. Streaks are the visible lines or uneven wipe marks described.
2. B - rather than Correct. This contrasts observation with an unsupported explanation.

05 • Conversations

1. The panel beside office eight - The glass-quality concern in the case.
2. The reported residue is on another desk - A cleaner checks the precise location of a complaint.
3. Checking the correction with the occupant - A cleaner returns after the assigned rework has been completed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A complaint names the wrong floor

A client says the second-floor mirror is streaked, then points to a photograph labeled third floor. The cleaner hasn't inspected either mirror.

Role A: Cleaner: clarify which location the photograph shows.

Role B: Client: confirm third floor and withdraw the second-floor location.

Possible opening: Before I request rework, which mirror does this photograph identify?

Success checks

- Confirm third floor.
- Avoid reporting both mirrors as defective.
- Request inspection of the identified surface.

Add a complication: The client says the mirrors look identical.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Giving a clear end-of-shift handover

Give each area a precise status and a named follow-up.

CASE

Rooms 301 and 302 have been cleaned; 302 awaits the supervisor's inspection. Room 303 was inaccessible and not cleaned. The incoming attendant can accept 303's access follow-up, while the supervisor owns 302's inspection. Report each status separately without deciding room release.

Teach this move

Cleaned, inspected, and released can be separate statuses under a site's arrangements. Do not turn a completed cleaning task into a broader authorization.

Vocabulary to check: room status, outstanding task, completion record, sign-off.

Model response

Room three-oh-one is cleaned. Three-oh-two is also cleaned, but the supervisor's inspection is still pending. Three-oh-three was inaccessible and hasn't been cleaned. Can you take the access follow-up for three-oh-three? I'll confirm the inspection request with the supervisor; please don't describe that pending check as a completed sign-off or a room-release decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The statuses let the next worker act without guessing.

Second-round challenge

A caller asks whether 302 can be released. Direct the release question to the responsible person.

Language-check answers

1. D - still pending Correct. The inspection remains unfinished despite completed cleaning.
2. D - I'll confirm access and update its status Correct. This explicitly accepts the named follow-up and reporting task.

05 • Conversations

1. Three rooms, three statuses - The end-of-shift case on the third floor.

2. A completed area has one limitation - A commercial cleaner gives a precise end-of-shift report.
3. The receiver cannot take the task - An outgoing cleaner finds that the intended colleague is assigned elsewhere.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A room number is read incorrectly

The outgoing attendant says room 416 awaits inspection. The incoming worker repeats 460. Room 460 is on another floor and isn't in this handover.

Role A: Outgoing attendant: correct the exact room number.

Role B: Incoming attendant: read back 416 and its pending inspection.

Possible opening: I said four-one-six, not four-six-zero.

Success checks

- Repeat digits distinctly.
- Confirm 416.
- Preserve awaiting-inspection status without changing 460.

Add a complication: A noisy corridor makes the final digits hard to hear.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All room numbers, buildings, times, counts, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice, not cleaning certification, chemical-use instruction, medical advice, or access authorization. Follow employer training and site procedures for products, equipment, privacy, waste, and hazards. Do not infer permission to enter, mix products, handle unknown waste, or repair equipment. This course addresses frontline cleaning exchanges rather than hospitality management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Janitors and Building Cleaners

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/building-and-grounds-cleaning/janitors-and-building-cleaners.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Maids and Housekeeping Cleaners

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/37-2012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.